PQC DAILY STUDY SERIES

Implementation Security of ML-KEM: Defending Against Side-Channel Attacks

Day 53 | Category: PQC Security and Implementation Date: 2026-11-10 | DAILY MONITORING

Understanding the Implementation Security of CRYSTALS-Kyber (ML-KEM)

While CRYSTALS-Kyber (ML-KEM) is designed to be mathematically secure against attacks from both classical and quantum computers, its real-world security depends heavily on the implementation. Physical attacks, which exploit information leaked during the execution of the cryptographic algorithm, are a significant threat. Side-channel attacks (SCAs) are a primary concern in this category.

What are Side-Channel Attacks (SCAs)?

Side-channel attacks do not break the mathematical foundation of an algorithm. Instead, they exploit physical leakage from the hardware running the cryptography. This leakage can include power consumption, electromagnetic (EM) emanations, or timing variations. By analyzing these "side-channels," an attacker can recover sensitive information, such as the secret key.

Vulnerabilities in ML-KEM Implementations

ML-KEM's security relies on the hardness of the Module Learning With Errors (MLWE) problem. However, specific operations within the algorithm can be vulnerable to SCAs if not implemented carefully. Key areas of concern include:

- **Number Theoretic Transform (NTT):** The NTT is a core component of ML-KEM for polynomial multiplication. Its operations can leak information if not implemented with constant-time execution.
- **Sampling Functions:** The generation of random numbers and polynomials from a Centered Binomial Distribution (CBD) can be vulnerable to timing or power analysis.
- **Decapsulation Process:** The decapsulation step, which involves re-encryption and comparison, is a critical point. Simple comparisons can be susceptible to timing attacks, where an attacker measures the time it takes to process different ciphertexts.

Countermeasures: Masking and Constant-Time Execution

To defend against SCAs, PQC implementations must incorporate specific countermeasures. Two of the most important are masking and constant-time execution.

Side-Channel Attack Countermeasures for ML-KEM

Countermeasure	Description	Targeted Attacks
Constant-Time Execution	Ensures that cryptographic operations take the same amount of time, regardless of the input data. This prevents attackers from learning secret information by measuring timing variations.	Timing Attacks
Masking	A technique to randomize the internal state of the cryptographic algorithm. It involves splitting sensitive variables into multiple "shares." An attacker would need to recover all shares simultaneously to reconstruct the secret, which is significantly harder.	Power Analysis, EM Attacks

Real-World Applicability in Internet Protocols

The security of ML-KEM in protocols like TLS 1.3 and SSH depends entirely on the quality of the underlying cryptographic library. For example, a TLS server using a vulnerable ML-KEM implementation could have its private keys extracted by a local or physical attacker monitoring its power consumption. This highlights the importance of using certified and hardened PQC libraries (like those validated by NIST's CAVP/CMVP programs) in all internet-facing applications.

Daily Quiz

1. What is the primary difference between a mathematical attack and a side-channel attack on a PQC algorithm?
2. Why is the decapsulation process in ML-KEM a critical point for side-channel vulnerabilities?
3. How does "masking" help to protect an ML-KEM implementation from power analysis attacks?